

Group Behavior

1. What is group?
2. Types of social group.
3. Why do people conform group behavior?
4. Why race, ethnicity, class and gender are important in group dynamics?

Group dynamics

1. Definition:

Sociologists explain that human beings live their lives as members of groups, and almost everyone wants a sense of belonging, which is the essence of group life. A social group is defined as two or more people who identify with and interact with one another. Group members share experiences, loyalties, and interests, and they think of themselves as a special “we.”

2. Types of social group:

i) Primary Group: A primary group is a small social group whose members share personal and lasting relationships. Members spend a great deal of time together, engage in many activities, and show real concern for one another. The family is described as society’s most important primary group. Primary groups are “primary” because they are among the first groups we experience and play a key role in socialization, shaping attitudes, behavior, and identity.

Group dynamics

ii) Secondary Group: A secondary group is a large and impersonal social group whose members pursue a specific goal or activity. Secondary relationships involve weak emotional ties and limited personal knowledge. These groups often exist for a short time and are usually more formal and polite. Examples include classmates in a large university course or people working in a company.

iii) Dyad and Triad Groups: The document explains that group dynamics change with group size. A dyad is a group of two members, and interaction tends to be intense but unstable because if one person withdraws, the group collapses. A triad has three members and is more stable because conflict between two people can be mediated by the third member, although two members may exclude the third.

iv) Reference Group: A reference group is a social group that serves as a point of reference for making evaluations and decisions. People use reference groups to assess their attitudes and behavior. Reference groups can be primary or secondary, and we can even use groups we do not belong to for reference in order to gain acceptance. E.g. students comparing themselves to top achievers.

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v) *In-Group and Out-Group*: Group membership creates in-groups and out-groups. An in-group is a social group toward which a person feels respect and loyalty, while an out-group is a group toward which a person feels competition or opposition. Tensions between groups sharpen group boundaries and give people a clearer social identity. However, members often hold overly positive views of their own group and negative views of outsiders. E.g. In-group: Fans of one football team (e.g., supporters of a local football club); Out-group: Fans of rival teams.

vi) *Network group*: A network as a web of weak social ties and are like “fuzzy” groups. Networks include many people who may come into occasional contact but lack strong boundaries and belonging. Networks can reach great distances and include large numbers of people, and they can become an important resource. E.g. job and career connections, Social media connections.

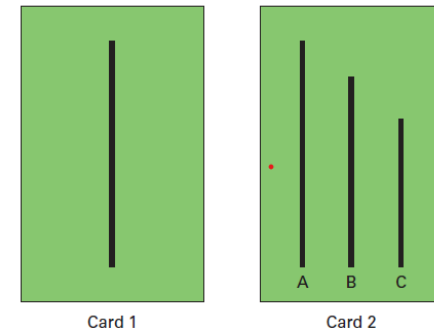
Group dynamics

3. Why do people conform to group behavior?

The groups influence behavior by encouraging **conformity**, because “fitting in” provides a sense of belonging and security. However, group pressure can also be harmful when it pushes individuals to behave against their judgment.

In **Solomon Asch’s** experiment, people were asked to match line lengths. Even though the correct answer was obvious, one-third of participants intentionally gave the wrong answer just to avoid standing out from the group. This shows that many people fear being socially isolated more than being factually wrong.

In **Milgram’s** study, participants obeyed commands to administer what they believed were painful electric shocks to others. Even when the victim screamed or went silent, many continued because they were pressured by authority and group norms. When people acted in groups, they delivered shocks three to four times higher than those acting alone—showing how group presence intensifies conformity.



Group dynamics

4. Why race, ethnicity, class and gender are important in group dynamics?

Why Race, ethnicity, class, and gender are important in group dynamics because they decide who has power, who belongs, who is heard, and who is excluded—often in ways that feel “natural” or “normal,” even though they are socially constructed.

i) They decide power and status inside groups: Groups are rarely equal spaces. People enter groups with different amounts of social power based on race, class, and gender. These differences affect:

who leads

whose opinions are taken seriously

who gets credit

who is interrupted or ignored

who is treated as “naturally competent”

So, even when a group claims to be neutral (like a classroom group or workplace team), inequalities from society often reproduce themselves inside the group.

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ii) They influence inclusion and exclusion: How groups draw boundaries: in-groups (“us”) and out-groups (“them”). These divisions are often based on visible identity markers like race and gender, or social markers like class.

This is important because people often:

favor their in-group; distrust out-groups

stereotype those outside the group

treat outsiders as less legitimate

These processes can create tension, discrimination, and conflict.

iii) They affect social identity and self-worth: People form a sense of self by comparing themselves to others and using groups as reference points. If someone is regularly treated as “less valuable” because of their race or class, it generates:

confidence; sense of belonging

aspiration; mental well-being

expectations for success

This is why group dynamics are not only about interaction—they influence identity.

Group dynamics

iv) They influence communication styles and expectations: Gender and class affect what people learn is “acceptable” behavior. For example:

Some groups may reward assertiveness, others see it as disrespect.

Women may be expected to be cooperative and emotionally supportive.

So differences in communication are often mistaken as personality traits, when they are actually socially patterned.

v) They explain how inequality is maintained through everyday life: One of sociology’s biggest insights is: inequality isn’t only created by laws and institutions—it is also created in daily interactions. Group dynamics matter because they are the “micro-level” setting where social inequality is reproduced:

who is invited into networks

who gets mentorship

who receives opportunities

who is excluded socially

This is how larger systems of inequality remain stable across generations.

Group dynamics

vi) They influence access to social networks and opportunities: Groups are not only about friendship or belonging—they are also gateways to resources. Social networks inside groups often determine:

- who gets information first; who gets job referrals

- who is invited to internships, events, or leadership roles

- who gets emotional and financial support

Because race, class, and gender influence who connects with whom, group networks can become unequal systems of opportunity. Even without intentional discrimination, people tend to form ties with those who are socially similar (homophily), which can limit upward mobility for marginalized groups.

Group dynamics

vii) Group creates conflict, resistance, and group solidarity: Race, ethnicity, class, and gender don't only create inequality—they also guide how groups form collective identities and act together. When people experience exclusion or discrimination, they may develop stronger solidarity with others who share the same identity. This can lead to:

- social movements (civil rights, feminist movements, labor unions)

- collective resistance

- community support systems

- stronger “in-group” unity against external pressure

At the same time, inequalities can also create internal tension when groups contain members with different identities (e.g., gender inequality inside a racial justice movement, or class divisions inside ethnic communities).